5th December 2013

Swindon Borough Council
Wat Tyler House
Beckhampton Street
Swindon
SN1 2JH

Dear Swindon Borough Council

Application Reference S/OUT/13/1555

Re: Outline planning permission for a sustainable urban extension for up to 2,380 dwellings, a mixed use local centre and mixed use areas, community uses, sheltered accommodation, a primary school, green infrastructure including formal and informal open space, sports facilities, sustainable drainage, engineering works including ground modelling, other infrastructure, demolition and the formation of new accesses from the A420, Old Vicarage Lane, Thornhill Road.

At: Eastern Villages; Land North of A420 South Marston and Rowborough Swindon Wilts

Thank you very much for the opportunity to respond on the above outline planning application. Wiltshire Wildlife Trust would like to make the following comments. At this outline stage these comments are general in nature with a few specific points highlighted. We would look forward to a much more detailed consultation and dialogue over any future detailed planning application and masterplan.

Green Infrastructure Framework

Wiltshire Wildlife Trust welcomes the inclusion of a comprehensive Green Infrastructure Framework (GIF). In particular it welcomes the 10 guiding objectives for the proposed GIF, including:

Guiding Objective 2:

'To ensure that the GIF Framework is multi-functional in its design so that it delivers long term landscape, biodiversity, recreation and sustainability benefits'.

It is also encouraging to see the recognition within the guiding principles of the GIF, for the need to re-establish coherent, resilient ecological networks (ref: NPPF para 117) within the green infrastructure throughout the proposed development.

However the Trust would like to see it confirmed that the GI proposed within the development and the components, hedgerows, meadows, swales etc, are part of an integrated GIF across the whole of the proposed Eastern Villages Strategic site (Swindon Local Plan Pre-submission draft). It is essential that as these development proposals come forward, they maximise the opportunities presented for net biodiversity gain across the whole of the Strategic site, and in this context are considered part of the overall GIF.

We would also like to confirm through this consultation some of the comments made in our submission of 21st February 2013 to the Swindon Borough Local Plan 2026 Pre-submission draft consultation, which are relevant to this specific consultation. We also expect to re-iterate this at the forthcoming Examination in Public of the Swindon Local Plan (expected during 2014). Original comment below:

NC3 Eastern Villages Page 179. *This policy appears to have removed the proposal to create a Landmark green infrastructure feature as part of this strategic area. We believe that the development of a new Landmark Nature Park is essential, and that this proposal should be re-instated. With an additional 8,000 houses and an anticipated 18,000 new residents it is essential that these residents have the opportunity to access and experience the natural environment. This would considerably enhance residents' Health and Wellbeing, and contribute to biodiversity targets. The new nature park should include the restoration of priority habitats and the provision of a new visitor/education centre.*

Therefore we propose that added to the ***Policy NC3*** *New Eastern Villages should be a new bullet point, 'shall provide a Landmark new Nature Park, including visitor/education centre'...*

...Swindon Borough Council has the opportunity through this Local Plan to set itself the ambitious target of enabling every new (and existing) resident of Swindon to have enhanced access to the natural environment through the provision of new community centred nature parks and visitor/education facilities. This will contribute significantly to healthy communities and the health and wellbeing benefits of the residents of Swindon. (ref: letter of 21st Feb 2013).

Wiltshire Wildlife Trust believes that providing facilities to meet the objectives of people accessing, and benefiting from the natural environment are fundamental in any new development of the scale proposed for this development site. This should include the restoration of wildlife habitats (and species), the preservation of existing wildlife sites (national and local), through the establishment of coherent ecological networks. This is consistent with the aspirations of the Swindon Green Infrastructure Strategy and national policy (NPPF). This should also include the provision of access routes to and through such sites, and the building of new community facilities, including education/visitor centres, within the development envelope of each of the strategic development sites.

The Trust would like to have the opportunity to discuss with Swindon Borough Council the wider detail of the ecological content of the of the Green Infrastructure, in terms of habitats proposed and how these would deliver the required ecological networks, biodiversity gain and connectivity across this site and the wider Eastern Villages Strategic Site. We would like to be fully involved in helping formulate the GI content of the master plan for the site.

Wiltshire Wildlife Trust, Background information

The Trust has considerable land management expertise, particularly in relation to management of woodlands, neutral grasslands (hay meadows and pastures), and chalk downlands. The Trust manages 50 nature reserves across Wiltshire and Swindon. Also we have our own farming operation (in support of our grazing management of neutral grasslands and chalk downland reserves). This includes over 1000 head of livestock sheep (550) and cattle (450). Within Swindon we manage Clout's Wood and Markham Banks, Kings Farm wood, Swindon Lagoons, Rushey Platt, Hagborne Copse and are also involved in supporting community management of Washpool and St Vincients Wood. Our biggest reserves at Blakehill and Clattinger Farm/Lower Moor Farm (close to Swindon) add up to approximately 600 hectares.

The Trust would bring 50 years' experience and advice in conservation and land management, project management, expertise in community engagement and volunteer training and involvement. Most of our reserves have some sort of community engagement and volunteer support groups helping support management and monitoring, and public engagement on site. WWT staff have great ecological expertise across many habitats and species.

The Trust also runs programmes, on climate change adaptation and mitigation, waste minimization, Adult and Youth Wellbeing programmes supporting mental health recovery through engagement with nature. We also have a variety of projects which engage directly with schools, particularly in the primary sector.

The Trust would be delighted to explore a significantly enhanced delivery partnership with Swindon Borough Council. The work of the Trust is backed up by considerable expertise amongst its staff. The Trust would like to contribute to the realisation of the vision for a sustainable Eastern Villages supported by significant community engagement and education activities.

Test against Swindon Local Plan pre-submission draft 2013

Policy SD3a The Trust confirms that this proposed development should be consistent with Policy SD3a (amended as proposed below).

Policy SD3a. We propose that added to first bullet point under policy SD3a are the words 'including net biodiversity gain' after the words ... environmental conditions....

Sustainable development should include and acknowledge the essential preservation of functional ecosystems in order to preserve the essential services that they provide. Development must not

impact further on these declining ecosystem services, and must make a positive contribution to their restoration and function.

"Humans rely on the way ecosystems services control our climate - pollution, water quality, pollination - and we're finding out that many of these regulating services are degrading," Bob Watson, chief scientific adviser to the Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs (Defra) and co-chairman of the NEA. "About 30% of the key ecosystem services that we rely on are degrading". Ref: National Ecosystem Assessment 2011. (from WWT response of 21st February 2013).

Policy IN1 Page 108 Infrastructure provision

The Trust confirms that this proposed development should be consistent with Policy **Policy IN1 Page 108** (amended as proposed by WWT on 21st February 2013).

Add bullet point, 'contribute to net biodiversity gain and preservation of ecosystem function'.

Policy IN2 Water supply and Waste water. Page 111.

The Trust confirms that this proposed development should be consistent with **Policy IN2 Water supply and Waste water. Page 111.** (amended as proposed by WWT on 21st February 2013)

This Policy needs to be stronger and make specific reference to future water supply demands having **no adverse** impact on the ecosystem service function of rivers and floodplains. In particular no adverse impact on nationally designated sites such as the River Kennet SSSI. It is acknowledged that Swindon is in an area that is seriously water stressed. The River Kennet is vulnerable to drought conditions and that water abstraction (for supply to Swindon) contributes to this. Ref: "Water resources in England and Wales - current state and future pressures", Environment Agency, December 2008.

Policy CM2 Active, Healthy and safe Lifestyles. Page 127

The Trust confirms that this proposed development should be consistent with **Policy CM2 Active, Healthy and safe Lifestyles. Page 127.** (amended as proposed by WWT on 21st February 2013)

We believe that added to the provision of multi-use community facilities, should be a bullet point indicating the provision of a 'network of community based visitor and education facilities', which promote and enhance peoples connection, understanding of and engagement with the natural environment.

Policy EN1 Green Infrastructure Network. Page 139.

The Trust confirms that this proposed development should be consistent with **Policy EN1 Green Infrastructure Network. Page 139.** (amended as proposed by WWT on 21st February 2013)

The Policy statement places significant emphasis on trees, hedges and woodlands. The green corridors which comprise the GI network should comprise a mixture of trees, hedges, woodlands, wetlands and grasslands and other habitats appropriate to the local soil and flooding conditions. They should be planned strategically and directly contribute to the restoration and re-creation of priority habitats and enhancement of ecological networks. (ref: NPPF para 117). We suggest that the Policy includes the words, 'enhance ecological networks and ecosystem functions'.

The Trust confirms its view in response to the consultation response (21st February 2013) that Swindon Borough Council has the opportunity through its Local Plan to set itself the ambitious target of enabling every new (and existing) resident of Swindon to have enhanced access to the natural environment through the provision of new community centred nature parks and visitor/education facilities, set within wide ranging green infrastructure of all of the proposed strategic sites. This will contribute significantly to healthy resilient communities and the health and wellbeing benefits of the residents of Swindon.

Thank you very much for your consideration of these comments.

Kind regards

Yours sincerely

Stephen Davis

Stephen Davis
Head of Conservation Policy